

DANA Article

Reinaldo Espina-Navarro¹, M^a Nieves Martínez-Alzamora², José Manuel Soler-Torro², and
Virtudes Mellado-García²

¹*Basque Center for Applied Mathematics (BCAM), Bilbao, Basque Country – Spain*

²*Department of Applied Statistics, Operational Research and Quality, Universitat Politècnica de València,
Valencia – Spain*

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Abstract

1 Introduction

The floods that affected the Valencia region in October 2024 have been described as one of the most severe natural disasters in recent Spanish history, resulting in 228 fatalities and affecting thousands of people. In such contexts of uncertainty and disruption, news media play a crucial role in society, as they are responsible for disseminating information and shaping how events are publicly interpreted (Cottle; Pantti, Wahl-Jorgensen, and Cottle). For this reason, media coverage contributes to the construction of meaning around disasters, influencing not only how they are understood but also how they are socially and politically responded to.

Disasters are not only objective events defined by their material consequences, but also socially constructed phenomena influenced by the media representations (Pantti, Wahl-Jorgensen, and Cottle). The way in which different media outlets select, frame and narrate these events, plays a critical role in defining their salience, perceived severity, and broader social implications. Rather than acting as neutral transmitters of information, media operate as *'amplification stations'* of risk, intensifying certain aspects of the event while downplaying others, thereby influencing public perception and collective responses (Kasperson et al.). This can be further understood through the framing theory, which posits that media do not simply report events but actively construct narratives by selecting, emphasizing and organizing specific aspects of reality (Scheufele). Frames operate by defining problems, attributing causes and suggesting moral evaluations or potential solutions (Entman).

However, the process of risk amplification is not neutral and may lead to distortions in how crises are represented and understood. In highly mediatized disaster contexts, the selection and intensification of specific elements can give rise to narratives that emphasize threat, urgency, and uncertainty in disproportionate ways (Cottle). Holm in (Holm) listed an excellent example of this phenomenon regarding the media coverage of Katrina Hurricane, the *New York Times* wrote: *"America is once more plunged into a snakepit of anarchy, death, looting, raping, marauding thugs, suffering infrastructure, a gutted police force, insufficient troop levels, and criminally negligent government planning"*. This is particularly evident in alarmist headlines, where linguistic and rhetorical choices tend to condense and dramatize complex events, often privileging emotionally charged interpretations over contextual nuance. As noted by (Molek-Kozakowska), headlines work as strategic devices that package information, activate emotional and cognitive responses, and frame the audience's understanding of the event. As a result, media coverage may contribute to the construction of alarmist narratives that frame disasters as unprecedented, uncontrollable, or escalating phenomena, potentially amplifying public fear

and shaping collective responses beyond the immediate material impact of the event (Altheide and Michalowski; Altheide).

Despite extensive research on media framing and risk communication in the context of natural disasters, existing studies tend to approach *alarmism* in broad or implicit terms, without providing a systematic framework to identify and quantify it (see next section). In particular, while previous work has examined emotional framing, fear appeals, sensationalism, and media hype in crisis contexts, relatively limited attention has been paid to the specific rhetorical patterns through which alarmist narratives are constructed. Importantly, not all negatively framed or emotionally charged headlines can be considered alarmist, highlighting the need for a more precise conceptualization of this phenomenon.

This article addresses this gap by introducing the concept of *rhetorical alarmism* as a multidimensional form of media framing that operates through identifiable linguistic and narrative structures. Building on existing literature on framing and risk amplification, the study proposes a framework to systematically capture how media discourse constructs disasters as exceptional, uncontrollable, or escalating events. Focusing on the case of the 2024 Valencia floods, the article aims to identify and quantify the presence of *rhetorical alarmism* in news headlines across different Spanish media outlets and social media platforms using an automated algorithm and an ad-hoc index, identifying statistical differences between media types, and examine their temporal evolution.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Media Coverage in Natural Disasters

Media play a central role in shaping the public understanding of disasters, as well as in structuring broader aspects of social life. As argued by (Thompson), the use of communication media transforms the spatial and temporal organization of social life, creating new forms of action and interaction while reconfiguring relations of visibility and power.

In the context of disasters, this transformative role becomes particularly salient. Media do not simply transmit information about disruptive events, but actively participate in their social construction. In a globalized communication environment, disasters can no longer be understood as isolated or purely natural occurrences, but as phenomena deeply entangled with media and communication flows. In this sense, media increasingly “enter into” disasters, shaping them from both the inside out and the outside in, by reconfiguring social relations and infusing events with cultural and political meanings.

Moreover, the expansion of contemporary media systems—characterized by their global reach, speed, and saturation—has intensified these dynamics. Disasters are now experienced in near real-time and on a global scale, enhancing their visibility and amplifying their perceived impact. As a result, disasters are not merely communicated by the media, but are to a significant extent constituted through the processes by which they are made visible, interpreted, and responded to in the public sphere.

2.2 A framework for Rhetoric Alarmism

3 Materials and Methods

3.1 Corpus Construction

This study analyzes a dataset of 1,340 headlines from different official news sources. The aim is to examine the presence of ‘alarmist’ framing in the coverage of the DANA event. The unit of analysis defined is the *journalistic headline* and in the case of social media, a sample for first *n-words* is taken from the post. The study period covers from 29th October to 30 November 2024, separating the data into two periods: the first from 29th October to 4th November (*Impact*), and the second from 5th

Media Type	Media Outlet
National Newspapers	<i>20 minutos, ABC, AS, EFE, El Mundo, El País</i> <i>EuropaPress, La Razón, La Vanguardia, Marca</i>
Local Newspapers	<i>Las Provincias, Levante EVM, El Mediterráneo,</i> <i>Torrent al día, Valencia Plaza</i>
National Radio	<i>La Cope, La Ser, Onda Cero</i>
Local TV	<i>7TeleValencia, À Punt, LaOchoTv</i>
National TV	<i>Antena 3, Telecinco, La Sexta, RTVE, Cuatro</i>
Social Media	<i>X, Facebook, Tiktok</i>

Table 1: Media outlets and social media included in the analysis

November to 30th November (*Post*). This division allows for a comparative analysis of the framing used in the immediate aftermath of the DANA event and in the subsequent weeks.

To ensure an appropriate representation of Spanish media ecosystem, the corpus includes headlines from a variety of sources, which include national and local scopes. The data set includes headlines listed on the Table 1 3.1:

Data collection followed a reproducible procedure based on structured search queries. Whenever possible, the *Advanced Google Search Engine* was used, combining boolean operators and site domains. When this method was insufficient and provided poor results, internal search engines of media sites were used specifically in social media. A limitation was encountered in the case of Instagram, as the platform currently does not provide a reliable date-filtering mechanism comparable to search engines or other social media platforms such as X (Twitter). This constraint makes it difficult to reproduce the same sampling procedure, as result we decided to exclude this social media from the final corpus construction.

The general search pattern was as follows:

(dana OR "gota fría" OR lluvias OR torrenciales) AND Valencia AND 2024
site:<domain>

Explicit criteria were defined to ensure consistency across the headlines collected.

Inclusion Criteria

- Explicit reference to the phenomenon under study: DANA or heavy rainfall in Valencia
- Publication within the defined temporal window
- Headlines must originate from verifiable sources (URL or platform identifier)
- For social media: a minimum relevance threshold ($\geq 1,000$ interactions, such as likes or shares)

Exclusion Criteria

- Irrelevant or ambiguous content not directly related to the event
- Duplicated entries or republished content
- News outside the temporal scope
- Non-comparable formats, lacking a clean headline structure (except for social media)

The sampling strategy consisted of selecting the first 50 relevant headlines per outlet, ordered according to their appearance in the search results and constrained by the predefined inclusion criteria.

In cases where media outlets did not yield sufficient results within the defined temporal window, only those headlines meeting the inclusion criteria were retained. Therefore, the number of observations varies across outlets, with some sources contributing fewer than the intended 50 headlines.

Following the data collection process, a structured database was constructed in which each observation corresponds to an individual headline. The final corpus comprises 1347 headlines. For each observation, a set of variables was defined: the *media outlet* (source name), publication date, and the full headline text. Additionally, other categorical variables were incorporated, such as *media type* (e.g., press, radio, television, or social media) and the *temporal phase* of the event (impact or post-event stage). The dataset also includes an estimate of audience reach and the corresponding URL linking to the original content. The information related to audiences was collected from ...

3.2 Data Preprocessing

Text Normalization and Linguistic Processing

Prior to analysis, a text standardization process was applied to ensure consistency and reduce noise. The cleaning procedure included converting all text to lowercase, replacing punctuation with whitespace, collapsing multiple whitespace characters into a single space, and removing residual special characters. For social media content, additional preprocessing steps were implemented, including the removal of hashtags (#), mentions (@), emojis, and other non-linguistic symbols.

Once the text was normalized, all headlines were lemmatized to improve pattern detection. This process transforms each word (token) into its canonical base form, thereby minimizing the impact of inflectional variations such as verb conjugations, plural forms, and gender agreement. Lemmatization was performed using the UDPipe library with a Spanish pre-trained model, which provides tokenization, part-of-speech tagging, and lemma extraction. Each headline was thus converted into a sequence of lemmas representing the original text. This lemmatized representation serves as the input for the subsequent regex-based detection process used to identify alarmist linguistic patterns.

4 Conclusions

We conclude that....

External data

The experimental dataset is available at....

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